

WORLD WAR I TANK

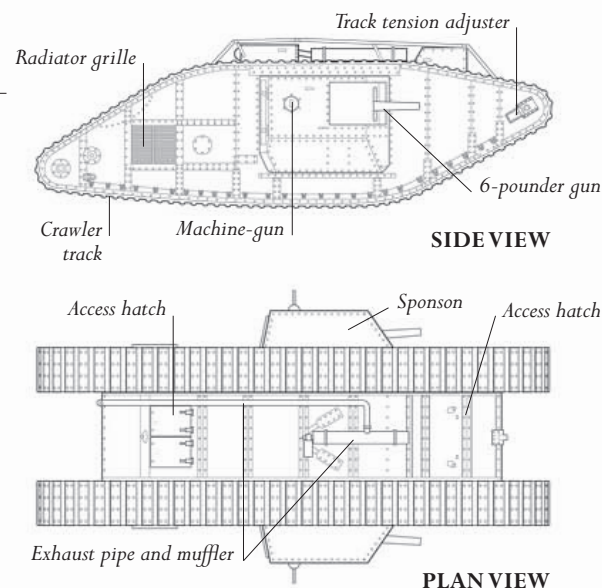
MARK V TANK

Tanks were first used by the British on the Somme in September 1916. Early models were unreliable, but showed strong fighting potential. Over 400 Mark Vs had entered service before the war's end.

The Mark V, introduced in 1918, was the last of the lozenge-shaped British heavy tanks to fight on the Western Front. As with all of its predecessors, the Mark V's thick armour reduced both its speed and mobility. The tank was employed to lead infantry across no-man's-land, smashing a path through barbed wire and trenches.

Although resistant to machine-guns, heavy tanks were vulnerable to artillery fire, and when operated over muddy

ground pitted with shell holes, they could also get stuck or break down. At the Battle of Cambrai in 1917, around 324 British heavy tanks carried out a mass attack on firm ground and demonstrated what the vehicle could achieve if properly used. Lighter, quicker tanks, such as the British Whippet and the French Renault FT-17 – which introduced the rotating gun turret – proved their worth in the relatively open combat of the war's later stages.



▲ MARK V TANK

The tank was 8.05m (26½ft) long and weighed 29.5 tonnes (29 tons). Its 112kW (150hp) Ricardo engine gave it a top speed of 7.4 kph (4½mph).

TANK EXTERIOR



▲ CRAWLER TRACK

The tank moved on two tracks – loops of riveted metal links that ran around rollers.



▲ FRONT VIEW

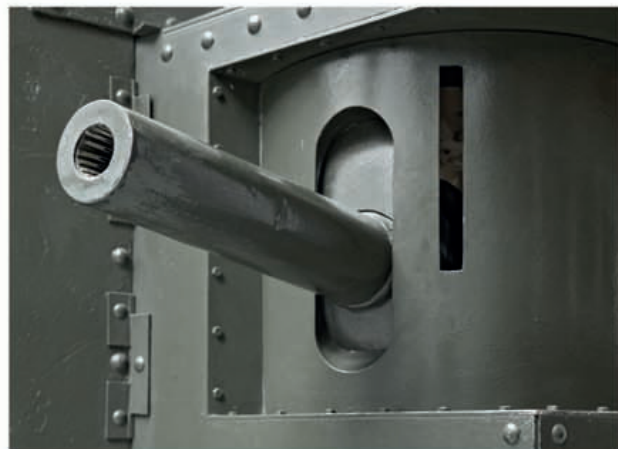
Enemy troops trained their fire on the vision ports, so tank crews began to wear face masks.

► “MALE” TANK

Versions with two 6-pounder guns and four Hotchkiss machine-guns were known as “male” tanks; “female” tanks were equipped only with machine-guns.

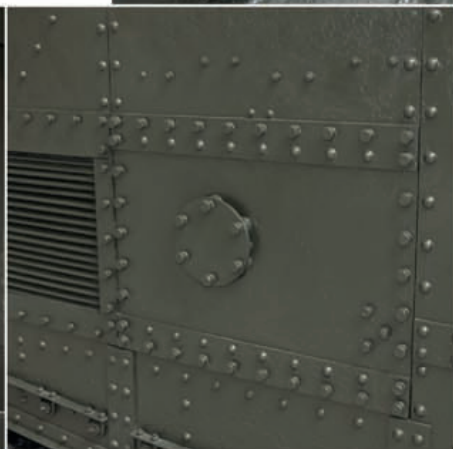
▼ ADJUSTER NUT

To give the correct traction, the tension in the tracks was altered by turning adjuster nuts.



▲ 6-POUNDER GUN

Two crew manned each of the quick-firing 6-pounders, which were located on either side of the tank in armoured projections called sponsons. Each sponson also mounted a machine-gun.



▲ ARMOUR

The Mark V was clad in riveted steel plates, up to 14mm (½in) thick, that could withstand German armour-piercing bullets. The engine radiator grille is visible on the left.

